Strange Fruit

By Neil LaBute

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *June is big month for weddings, and for legislation about same-sex marriage. On June 16, 2008, clerks in several California counties began issuing marriage licenses to thousands of same-sex couples.*

ACTOR 2: *Over the next few months, 18,000 same-sex couples were married in California. The ruling, however, was short-lived. On November 4, 2008, opponents of the freedom to marry pushed through a constitutional amendment that stripped same-sex couples of marital rights.*

ACTOR 1: *The issue of gay marriage was fought in the courts for years. It wasn't until June 26, 2015 that the United States Supreme Court ruled in favor of the freedom to marry, ending marriage discrimination not only in California, but across the country.*

ACTOR 2: *In the words of Supreme Court Justice Anthony Kennedy . . . "No union is more profound than marriage, for it embodies the highest ideals of love, fidelity, devotion, sacrifice, and family. . .*

ACTOR 1: *. . . marriage embodies a love that may endure even past death. . . these men and women . . . ask for equal dignity in the eyes of the law. The Constitution grants them that right."*

TOGETHER: *Strange Fruit by Neil LaBute*

SILENCE. DARKNESS. A man, TOM, standing in a bright light, wearing a tux. He talks to us. Another man, JERRY, in a tux, stands next to him. Smiling. They resemble the figures on the top of a wedding cake

TOM: . . . I love [guys]. I do. I'm really sort of just into [them], you know? [Guys]. And that's what got all this started, I mean, how I ended up here in the first place. Because of that. The ["guy"] situation. *(Beat.)* And I had, like, no idea when I was younger, I really didn't! None. I wasn't secretly putting on my mom's dresses or makeup at night or . . . or . . . reading the Hardy Boys and getting a . . . *(embarrassed gesture)* nothing like that.

JERRY: I loved the Hardy Boys, are you kidding me?! They were so cute, with all

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

their . . . or maybe I'm thinking of the show. With Parker Stevenson. Yeah, that's it! That's the Hardy Boys I know. The TV ones. God, he was good-looking . . . *Parker* . . .

TOM: Funny thing is, I was ***totally*** into girls when I was younger. Seriously, I was!

JERRY: I grew up in Oregon. Beautiful part of the country

TOM: So I did the whole "marriage and kids" thing when I was ***nineteen*** . . . I did. Yeah! Why I don't know, because I was supposed to? Maybe. It was expected of me and so that's what I did. I did that . . . made it through sixteen years. ***Sixteen***. *(Beat.)* No, "made it through" sounds so -- accurate. I don't wanna be like that, dump on her or be all . . . Well that's what I did. I ***just*** made it through. ***Barely***.

JERRY: I met him when he was living in Chicago, divorced and just starting to dip his toe into the scene a little bit -- totally not sure about what he wanted, how he saw his life going in the next however long ... but he did like [guys]. That part was a given. Oh yeah!

TOM: I already said that, didn't I? And it's true . . . the second I did, ***that***, it was like a light went off in my head and all these, like, *fireworks* and stuff ... big letters up in the sky saying "YES! WE'RE HOME!!" *(Beat.)* It was pretty awesome . . .

JERRY: He couldn't get enough and I was, you know what? It's like -- hey, I've always been a very giving person! Who am I to stop a guy who wants to learn? And this dude just couldn't get enough ...

TOM: And somehow we sorta just stayed together and became, I dunno, a couple, I guess . . . I mean, pretty soon he was moved into my place and there we were. Him and me. This . . . ***couple***. In a relationship.

JERRY: I had always been looking for someone. I mean, a guy . . . Someone special, who gets me.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

TOM: Anyway! Enough about us . . . trust me, it was working and if it does, ***when*** it does -- in life, I'm saying -- you shouldn't question happiness. Not ever.

JERRY: He was just a funny guy, really. That's what I liked about him. *(Beat.)* And great with his kids -- on the phone, anyway. He's not allowed to have them out to see him; they're in Orlando so he has to fly there if he wants to be around 'em at all, and that's . . . *(Beat.)* And that's how it went and suddenly, you know how it is . . . like, five years go by! We're looking in the mirror one morning -- we love to shave at the same time, share the water and, and the, you know, use the same little brush thingie with the soap --and, my god, I'm looking at myself and I say to him, "Jesus Christ, look at me. I'm ***thirty-nine*** years old." *(Beat.)* He leans over -- doesn't say a word -- just sort of lowers his head toward me, this little peck on my cheek. Then he whispers to me, "Wait'll next year. Forty's a bitch . . . "

TOM: He had a drop of foam on his nose, like a little puppy. Really cute, if you wanna know the truth . . .

JERRY: And we just stood there, bare-chested and with these towels on and started kissing. It was *so* good. Just . . . anyway, that's when he asked me. Said "Let's get married."

TOM: Which was a big deal, right? I mean, like I said, I'd already done it before and it was, well, whatever . . . it was what it was. My kids are terrific. *(Beat.)* Anyway, we'd even talked about marriage before but living in Chicago it was always about ***civil unions*** and ***domestic partnerships***. all this s*** that wants to be the same, to give us a little hope that people are about to stop being so goddamn idiotic about something so basic, so simple if they'd just let it be but it's . . . anyway, he told me that he had this dream. About it . . . Like, a wish.

JERRY: I just wanted it to be the same as anyone else, you know? Except two

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

guys on top of the cake, in tuxes -- really cute and both of us looking . . . it's stupid, I know, but I had ***actual*** dreams about it! Since I was a kid.

TOM: We kinda just watched and waited, without saying too much about it and yet nothing ·at all was changing so we thought maybe we could move to another state or, . . . or . . . you know -- but years go by and finally I say it as we stand there in the bathroom shaving. I'm the one to say it but we're both thinking it. Let's make this thing real! **Marriage**.

JERRY: Boom! Next day we've got tickets, we're off to California -- there's a window out there for us, I mean, we're two active, informed, vibrant people, right? We see what's going on in the world and it turns out there's, like, this five-month period in 2008 where that golden state near the ocean comes to its senses and says, "Yes, it's okay to be who you are" and we run out there like everyone else. Do this thing before anybody can say "no" to us again. And they do, they close that thing down like a book snapping shut, a few months later. Darn! But we do it. We get married.

TOM: We looked amazing -- I mean, yes, it was just the courthouse and all, but we did the whole deal he'd been wanting. Tuxes and, and just the entire . . . we were pretty much awesome. Standing there in the hall and . . . well, people were staring. That's all I'm gonna say. They were. ***Staring***.

JERRY: Just like I'd dreamed about. Seriously.

TOM: And we were just giddy the rest of the day. We snuck off to San Diego to be at that hotel that was in the movie with Marilyn Monroe and the guys dressing up like two women . . . you know the one! It's ummmmm . . .

JERRY: I'd never been to the Hotel del Coronado just gorgeous, this big ol' place propped up on the beach there . . . just very . . .

TOM: I took my tux off but I could not get my husband -- or ***wife*** or whatever

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

the hell I was gonna call him now -- he wouldn't take his off! Said he was gonna go downstairs and get some cigarettes . . .

JERRY: My one vice.

TOM: He'd been a smoker for years -- works out ***religiously*** but wouldn't think of giving up his nicotine! *(Smiles.)* He was standing there, at the door to the room, smiling at me, this big grin on his face. Asking me if I wanted anything. Some Twinkies or whatever.

JERRY: Somebody loves "Hostess."

TOM: I said "No thank you, I'm a married man now . . ." and we laughed and I blew him a kiss. Out he went.

JERRY: They didn't have any Marlboros there in the little gift shop so I went out into the streets. Looking for a 7-Eleven.

TOM: And . . . apparently . . . he ran into three guys who were coming up from a swim. Just some college kids from what the news said . . . and the police report.

JERRY: I was walking along in my tux, carrying a bag of mangoes and one of those stupid roses that you buy -- the single ones with a bit of plastic around the petals -- they keep 'em right up there by the checkstand so I got one for my fella . . .

TOM: And they must've said something because I know that . . . he could never let it go . . . you know? ***Ever***. Some guy two feet taller than him and ten years younger and he'd go after 'em like a little rooster if it was about us or being gay or, like, any of the stuff he believed in. Those kids in Africa or . . . or Amnesty International -- he'd be up in your face and telling you that you're full of s***! *(Laughs.)* That was just him. You know?

JERRY: I remember these surfer boys passing . . .

TOM: He wasn't found until the next morning. Down by the rocks, where the

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

water's . . .

JERRY: It's just funny . . . one day I'm standing in Chicago, the next thing you know I'm walking down a street with palm trees on it! I mean, ***palm*** trees!! With a rose in my hand and a paper bag full of strange fruit and, I dunno, this . . . love, I guess. Yeah, ***love*** in my heart for him and everybody else. Right? Even these three guys who are moving toward me now . . .

TOM: The story made the papers and was kind of a big deal, especially after all the . . . anyway. Yeah.

JERRY: Three boys who are getting louder as they come . . .

TOM: One day, few months later, somebody sent me a picture of us, before all that, standing on the courthouse steps as we waited in line to go in -- and I keep it out where I can see it now; I'll give it a glance when I head off to work or out for a run, that kinda thing -- it's of the two of us, both in our suits and smiling and from a distance or, if you stand back from it just a bit, you know what?

JERRY: I couldn't see their faces but they were laughing-and yelling and the sun was just behind them as they came closer . . .

TOM: We're like that couple you see on top of a cake. That little plastic couple, only it's two guys. ***Us***. Vibrant and young and frozen for a moment. I mean . . . well, you get what I mean, right?

JERRY: They were laughing . . .

TOM: Us standing there and smiling, as if all was right with our lives and not anything could possibly go wrong. You know?

JERRY: And they were getting louder and rowdier but to me, on this day and how I was feeling . . . it sounded like little birds singing.

TOM: As if nothing in the whole wide world was able to scare us or hurt us . . .

JERRY: These beautiful little birds . . . singing just to me from up in Heaven above

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

. . .

TOM: . . . or frighten us. No. Not us. Not ever again . . .

(Suddenly a light over JERRY blinks eff and out. He is now lost in the darkness. Hands unlock. TOM stands alone in the Jading light. TOM tries to smile but this too Jades away. SILENCE. DARKNESS.)

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Neil LaBute
Book: Plays for Two
ISBN: 978-0345804549
Publisher: Vintage
Date (Month/Year): March 2014

AWARD HISTORY

2012 National Qualifier
FL State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY